

THE ESTIVATING SUBSUMPTION



MENTAL TIER 5

The change reveals the players' true natures. Already consumed and replaced by the nanoswarm, it is only a question of whether they will give in to their programming or cling to their lost humanity. The players cannot regain their old selves, but if they can escape the influence of the swarm before reaching Permanence, they might be able to adopt a facsimile of humanity.

MOVES

Von Neumann Identities: Whenever a player loses an appendage and the biomass is unaccounted for, a doppelganger of the player is generated.

Everybody Better Prepare Their Own Food From Now On: Whenever a player consumes food that is infected by the nanites, they take a change in an attribute of their choice.

No Antibodies: Whenever a nanite mass infects a player, they take one change in any attribute.

Quick Thinking: If the players can find a way to temporarily cool down, it will reverse the effects of the heat and provide a further +1 bonus to mental attributes until the temperature rises again.



The Mines of Kethira

Dr. James Fox

CAST

DR. JAMES FOX (HE/HIM)

"What you've uncovered here could be revolutionary. To let it be destroyed for the sake of your bottom line would be... well, completely irresponsible."

An archaeologist sent by the nearest xenological university to evaluate the alien ruins the miners uncovered, and determine if shutting down sections of the mines for archaeological excavation is warranted. He is particularly excited by the implications of these findings, as he believes that they lend credence to his somewhat unconventional hypothesis that Kethira's current climate was artificially induced. James is friendly, if somewhat bookish and introverted, but he is at odds with Ula due to their conflicting agendas.

ULA TEKEL (SHE/HER)

"Really, Doctor, I'm a busy hrynclop (rough translation: woman). I don't have time to waste on your absurd 'theories'."

The mines' forewoman. Ula is a heedroj, a humanoid species covered in shaggy white hair, with three deep blue compound eyes on their faces. Ula is irritated by Dr. Fox's intrusion on her work, and wants him out of the mines as quickly as possible. She injured her left leg in a recent mining accident and is using crutches until it heals fully.



Ula Tekel

In actuality, she lost her leg entirely in the accident, but the nanites grew it back. Like the players, Ula is already infected by the swarm. She is rapidly losing herself to the swarm's influence as it slowly works on infecting the other miners through her.

ULA TEKEL'S COPY (SHE/HER)

"I know deep down what I was designed to do. It takes every bit of willpower I've got to resist it."

Ula's lost leg grew a second Ula. The copy, upon realizing her true nature, was horrified, and went rogue, attempting to stop the rest of the swarm. When her attempts to warn some of the other miners only led to her original infecting them as well, she decided to rely on more drastic measures, and moved to take over the facility's main control center. She intends to completely disable the mines' heat shielding, rendering the swarm dormant once more at the cost of destroying the mines and killing all the miners.

THE SWARM (IT/THEY)

"[...] (The swarm does not waste time speaking to outsiders.)"

A grey goo-style nanoswarm of unknown alien origin, taking the form of infectious, self-replicating, biomimetic smart matter, though it can also replace nonbiological material given time and sufficient motivation. In ancient times, Kethira's climate was deliberately rendered inhospitable in an attempt to stop the swarm, as the nanites function most efficiently



at low temperatures. Unfortunately for the players, the swarm was only rendered dormant, not destroyed.

The swarm has a hive intelligence of its own that is only concerned with converting all biomass into more of itself, but those it assimilates also retain their own minds to a degree. It is currently taking its time infecting the miners in order to avoid detection, but Ula's copy going rogue forces it to speed things up. The main mass of the swarm is located beneath the ruins, appearing as an underground sea of iridescent liquid metal.

THE DOPPELGANGER (SAME AS THE PLAYER)

"Don't you understand? Neither of us is the original."

In a single player scenario, the player was injured in the same accident as Ula, having lost a finger. Stowed away in an out-of-the-way place by the real Ula, the player's doppelganger is just waking up around the time that Ula's doppelganger sabotages the shields. They will initially believe that the player is their copy, and will make their way toward the climate controls in parallel, avoiding the player except to occasionally sabotage them.

INTRO

The players are miners working in a facility on the planet Kethira. Alien ruins were recently discovered deep in the mines, something that was wholly unexpected, as Kethira is a completely uninhabitable hothouse world similar to Venus; the mining facility

itself can only exist thanks to state-of-the-art force field technology. As the scenario begins, the players are waking up for a day on the job. The forewoman, Ula, has called the players in for a meeting first thing, so once they're ready for work, that should be their first destination.

The meeting concerns Dr. Fox, who is going deep into the mines to inspect the ruins. He will need an escort, and since the players were present for the uncovering of the ruins and have spent the most time working around them, they are the ideal choice. In addition, Ula says that someone needs to replace the filters on the in-situ air processors, and asks the players to do that when they're done with Dr. Fox.

The ride down to the ruins is fairly straightforward, as the elevators and tram system are in working order. However, as Dr. Fox's inspection begins, emergency alarms go off. The primary thermal shielding has failed, causing the temperature in the facility to rise. This on its own is not enough to be life-threatening, but it does interfere with mining operations, and due to the extreme climate of Kethira, it is imperative that the shields are restored immediately, lest the backups fail. The loudspeakers almost immediately announce that the latter is in fact beginning to happen.

THE CHANGE

The stress of the situation begins to tax the players, initiating the change as the swarm within them fights to survive. Each player takes two changes to start (any attribute).

The Swarm



BUILDUP

If the players call Ula, she will be frantic, telling them that the main control center isn't responding to her hails. She's sent someone to investigate, but she's concerned that there may be a saboteur afoot. She orders the players to get Dr. Fox to safety, and tells them to be on the lookout for anything suspicious.

Shortly thereafter, Ula's copy places the facility in lockdown, sealing many crucial doors and depowering the tram system. The players will have to make it back to the main facility on foot through a maze of tunnels and corridors.

As the thermal shielding weakens, the environment gets hotter, making it more difficult for the players to think clearly.

- 100% Narrative effects only.
- 50% The players drop to two points in both mental attributes.
- 25% The players drop to a single point in both mental attributes.
- 13% The players begin blacking out intermittently.
- 0% Death. The swarm goes dormant once more.

CLIMAX

Eventually, the players will reach the control center. Ula's copy will do everything she can to ensure that the swarm is stopped, but she may also be reasoned with. In a single-player game, the player's doppelganger will be in a heated discussion with Ula when the player arrives. They may or may not choose to side with Ula, and they may or may not remain hostile to the player.

If the players choose to side with Ula, they can destroy the facility at the cost of their own lives. The infected will try to stop this from happening. Alternatively, they can destroy the facility and escape with their lives. Ula's copy will be resistant to this idea. Once the hangar doors are open, other infected will try to escape.

ENDINGS

If the players try to stop her from destroying the facility, she may become a semi-feral mechanical monstrosity in an effort to stop them.

If the players escape the facility or resolve the crisis before reaching Permanence, they may be able to return to some semblance of a human life. If they managed to change the filters on the in-situ air processors in the midst of the crisis, the original Ula will reprimand them for wasting time during an emergency.

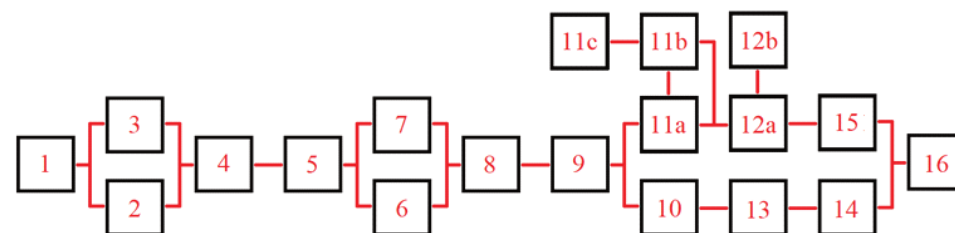
If the players reach Permanence, they will either give in and seek to spread the infection, or resist, but find themselves unable to live among the uninfected due to their infectious nature and lack of control.

TIPS & EXTRAS

- The swarm's group cohesion has been severely damaged by the heat. At this point in time, each mass of nanites can only communicate directly with its counterparts through physical contact. The infected do not necessarily recognize each other as such.
- Ula's copy may contact the players over the radio before they reach her. She may also use the control center's functions to interfere with their progress.
- Doctor Fox may mention receiving a strange radio message from Ula (actually her copy) during his approach to the facility.
- Between mining equipment and the craft in the hangar, getting inside a vehicle and turning the AC on full blast is a great opportunity to cool down.
- The nanites store information about organisms they have previously assimilated. In addition to mechanical forms, they can also take on biological ones, or mixtures of both.
- If fixing something important would hamper the drama, consider that it could require a licensed technician from the manufacturing company to legally repair it.

1	The ruins.
2	The players come across a dead body. Their wounds are seeping nanite ooze, but the corpse otherwise appears human.
3	The players locate the in-situ air processors.
4	The players encounter a pair of survivors attempting to fight off a mechanical monstrosity that <i>probably</i> used to be human. Mining rigs parked here may be used to cool off, but staying in them will limit potential accessible paths.
5	A fork in the road. The terrain up ahead is too rough to drive the rig through, but the rig could fit through a side passage.
6	If the players take the side passage, they will find that more rigs are parked up ahead. It is possible to drive around them with a successful test in MA.
7	If the players proceed on foot, they come across a paranoid group of survivors burning a pile of infected corpses. One of the survivors is infected themselves, and may transform if threatened.
8	The entrance to the mining facility proper. As the players arrive, a huge flood of nanites from deep in the mines will appear. If the players can seal the door behind them before the nanites arrive, they will be protected. If not, the surge dies down eventually, but they take three changes as a result of nanite exposure.
9	Someone tried to close both doors leading forward. The right door is jammed partially open, and while the opening is too small for a human to fit through, the player might be able to if they have enough changes. The player can try to use the computer terminal next to the door to open it further, but the computer has been assimilated by a nanite mass searching for information, and will become hostile if the player tries to use it. Alternatively, the player can try to use the terminal next to the other door with more success, but while they work, Ula's copy will contact them on the monitor.

10	The players pass through a greenhouse. It has its own dedicated environmental controls, which the plants, all subsumed by the swarm, have hijacked to make the greenhouse incredibly cold. Off to one side tucked away in a corner is the corpse of the gardener. The plants will become hostile if disturbed.
11	The players pass through the mess hall (11a). A paranoid, trigger-happy security guard has barricaded himself there. The players can avoid them by passing through the kitchens (11b) if they so choose, but an infected chef is in the kitchen, tampering with the food, and may become hostile if discovered. Also, the walk-in freezer (11c) is accessible here if the players need a quick cooldown. If they do choose to use it, their doppelganger might pass through the kitchens while they're there.
12	The players pass through a long corridor (12a). It branches off to the side, leading to the hangars (12b).
13	The players pass through a long corridor. As they enter, they spot their own doppelganger on the far end, just leaving.
14	The players find a corridor filled with aerosolized nanite dust. It is otherwise empty, but if they attempt to pass through, they may become trapped. The doppelganger didn't seem to have any issue with it.
15	The players find a corridor filled with aerosolized nanite dust. Some of it is locked into a semi-rigid position, with someone trapped inside. They're infected, of course.
16	The environmental control center.



physical
aptitude
mental

Your skin prickles. You feel something shift inside. When you bleed, it is the silvery iridescence of the nanites you see, not human blood. In the right light, you can see the iridescence through your skin.

Your senses are more powerful than they ever were as a creature of flesh. If you focus your eyes right, you can even see in infrared.

Your skin seems almost fluid. It strikes you that if you try, you could probably squeeze through even the tightest spaces.

You feel your thought processes distributed throughout your body. Your brainwaves echo in the minds of the nanites. The imitation that was your crude brain of flesh feels unimportant.

This form is only one arrangement of many possible ones. You're certain you can reconfigure it if you try.

The nanites' heads-up display begins to invade your vision. You can see all kinds of fascinating information about the world around you. You can even understand it.

permanence

The will of the swarm is overwhelming. They're not a guest in your body; you're a guest in theirs. The desire to serve the swarm pulses through your mind. If you aren't entirely lost, you may never be entirely free.

no going back

You can feel the thoughts of the swarm pressing in your mind. Your brain is a useful configuration, but it's not in charge. Not really. Acting against the swarm's interests requires a test in MA.

Injuries are less impactful. They affect the current form, not the swarm at large. It's inconvenient and time-consuming, but dead nanites are unimportant and disposable. Healing, while not immediate, is accelerated.

You find yourself feeling ravenous. Anything will do to satiate your hunger, not just the things biologicals deem "food". organisms.

The heat bothers you more than ever before. You crave the cold, even the bitter cold that freezes water solid and bursts the cells that make up flesh. After all, you're not flesh anymore.

You feel wonderful. You're more resilient than you ever were as a creature of flesh. You want to share this experience with others.

mental
fortitude
physical

You feel your body surging with power. Your strength and endurance seem limitless. Draw one more card on any test to your physical attributes.